Past simple vs past perfect; used to

Goal: To narrate past events in the right order using the past simple and the past perfect, and to describe past habits and states with **used to**.

The idea in two lines: The past simple tells what happened at a finished time in the past. The past perfect goes one step further back: it shows the earlier of two past actions, while **used to** describes what was true or habitual in the past but is no longer.

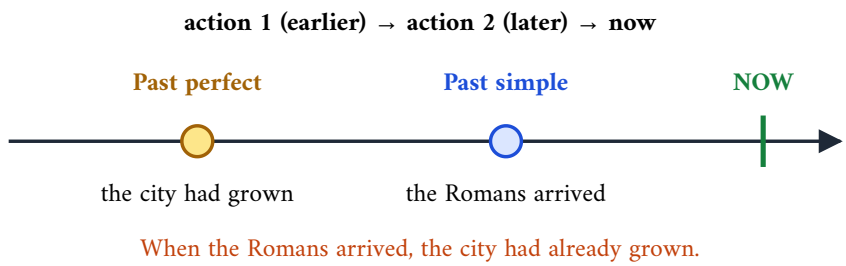


Figure 1: The past perfect marks the earlier of two past actions; the past simple marks the later one.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Past simple** (V + -ed / irregular form): a completed action at a definite past time: *The Phoenicians traded across the sea.*
2. **Past perfect** (had + past participle): an action completed before another past action or time.
3. **Time markers** with the past perfect: *before, after, by the time, already, just, when, until.*
4. With **after** the past perfect goes in the earlier action; with **before** it usually goes in the main clause: *They had built walls before the war started.*
5. **Used to** (used to + base verb): a past habit or state that has stopped: *People used to write on papyrus.*
6. Negative and question: didn't use to / Did … use to …? (no *-d* after *did*).

🟢 Examples

1. Join: *The empire collapsed. Then the city lost its trade.* **Solution:** After the empire **had collapsed**, the city **lost** its trade.
2. Correct the verb: *Ancient Egyptians use to build pyramids.* **Solution:** Ancient Egyptians **used to build** pyramids (a finished past habit).
3. Complete: *By the time archaeologists (reach) the tomb, thieves (steal) the gold.* **Solution:** reached / had stolen. **Explanation:** the theft happened first.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Using the past perfect for a single past action with no other past reference.
- Writing *had went* instead of the past participle *had gone*.
- Writing *didn't used to*; the correct form is *didn't use to*.
- Confusing *used to + verb* (past habit) with *be used to + -ing* (be accustomed to).

🟡 Quick review

- Past simple = finished action at a known past time.
- Past perfect = had + V3, the earlier past action.
- After + past perfect, then past simple.
- Used to = old habit or state, no longer true.

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